

Project Summary

In February 2025, Ashland Community and Technical College began offering an Associate in Arts program at Little Sandy Correctional Complex in Sandy Hook, Kentucky.

Prison to Profession explores whether there is a gap between the education levels of incarcerated individuals and the education typically required for high-wage, high-demand jobs in Kentucky.

By identifying these gaps, the college can better demonstrate need for the program—information that may support program planning, accreditation processes, grant applications, and outreach to potential students.

Key Findings

Analysis of U.S. Census microdata and Kentucky labor market projections revealed the following:

- Incarcerated individuals in Kentucky are more likely to have completed some college or less and are significantly less likely to hold a college degree compared to the general population.
- They are more likely than non-incarcerated Kentuckians to be working in jobs projected to grow by 5% or more (“high-demand”), but less likely to be in jobs paying \$50,000 or more (“high-wage”)—indicating that many incarcerated individuals work in low-paying but in-demand roles.
- A heatmap of jobs by required education level showed:
 - Associate degrees accounted for 121 occupations that were both high-demand and high-wage.
 - Postsecondary nondegree awards (such as certificates or diplomas) accounted for 81 occupations that were both high-demand and high-wage.
 - If incarcerated students transfer to a 4-year institution of higher education after completing an associate’s degree, they could become eligible for over 600 occupations that fall into both high-wage and high-demand categories—more than any other education level analyzed.

These findings highlight the importance of not only offering certificate, diploma, and associate degree programs to incarcerated individuals, but also building pathways for students to continue their education after release.

Limitations and Data Issues

- The dataset does not include a direct “incarcerated” flag. Incarceration status had to be estimated using variables such as group quarters type, age, and income. This approach may have excluded some individuals or introduced classification errors.
- Some individuals were dropped during the merge of ACS housing and demographic data because their serial numbers were not found in the housing dataset. This likely reflects missing or excluded housing data for certain households, such as those in institutional settings.
- Although the Census dataset is large, the above merging issue as well as limiting the analysis to Kentucky left a sample of 504 likely incarcerated individuals, which restricts regional or subgroup analysis.

Limitations and Data Issues (con't)

Despite these limitations, the analysis provides meaningful insight into the mismatch between educational preparation and economic opportunity for incarcerated Kentuckians.

Additional Considerations and Applications

For future projects, cleaned data from this project can also be used to explore the benefits of specific programs at Ashland Community and Technical College, especially those for which an associate's degree is not strictly required but common and desirable.

The cleaned data from this project can also be used to explore the benefits of and need for potential occupational training programs ACTC does not already offer.